
Abstract

- What are the main purposes of the study?
- Who was studied (sample, sample size, special characteristics)?
- How were the subjects selected and assigned to conditions?
- To what conditions were the subjects exposed?
- What type of design was used?
- What are the main findings and conclusions?

Introduction

- What is the background for the study (briefly)?
- What in current theory, research, or clinical work makes this study useful, important or of interest?
- What is different or special about the study in focus, methods, or design to address a need in the area?
- Is the rationale clear regarding the constructs to be assessed?
- What specifically are the purposes, predictions, or hypothesis?

Method

Participants

- Who are the participants and how many are there in this study?
- Why was this sample selected in light of the research goals?
- How was this sample obtained, recruited, and selected?
- What are the demographic characteristics of the sample (e.g., sex, age, ethnicity, race, socioeconomic status)?
- What, if any, inclusion or exclusion criteria were invoked, that is, what were the selection rules to obtain the participants?
- How many of those participants who were eligible or recruited actually were selected and participated in the study?
- Was informed consent solicited? How and from whom, if special populations were used?

Materials

- What, if any, presentation or recording apparatus were used – computers, video cameras, timing devices, etc.?
- Where was the research conducted – laboratory or natural setting?
- Was there a specific “setting”, whether laboratory or natural, the details of which may be important to the procedure or the results of the study?

Procedures

- Where was the study conducted (setting)?
- What measures, materials, equipment, or apparatus were used in this study?
- What is the chronological sequence of events to which subjects were exposed?
- What intervals elapsed between different aspects of the study (assessment, treatment, follow-up)?
- If assessments involve novel measures created for this study, what data are offered regarding about reliability and validity?
- What variation in administration of conditions that emerged over the course of the study in ways that may introduce variation within or between conditions?
- What procedural checks were completed to avert potential sources of bias in implementation of the manipulation and assessment of the dependent measures?
- What checks were made to ensure that the conditions were carried out as intended?

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- What else does the reader need to know to understand how subjects were treated and what conditions were provided?

Design

Note: Sometimes information about the design is included in the 'Participants' or the 'Procedure' sections, and sometimes, if the design is sufficiently complex, in a separate section – either way, you need to be able to identify the following:

- How were the subjects assigned to conditions or groups?
- How many groups were included in the design?
- How are the groups similar and different in how they are treated in the study?
- Why are these groups critical to address the questions of interest?

Results

- What are the primary measures and data upon which the predictions depend?
- What analyses are to be used and how specifically do these address the original hypotheses and purposes?
- Are the assumptions of the data analyses met?
- If multiple tests are used, what means are provided to control error rates?
- Prior to the experimental conditions, were groups similar on variables that might otherwise explain the results (e.g., diagnosis, age, other demographic variables)?
- Are data missing due to incomplete measures (not filled out completely by the subjects) or due to loss of subjects? If so, how are these handled in the data analyses?
- Are there ancillary analyses that might further inform the primary analyses or exploratory analyses that might stimulate further work?

Discussion

- What are the major findings of the study?
- How do these findings add to research and support, refute, or inform current theory?
- What alternative interpretations can be placed on the data?
- What limitations or qualifiers must be placed on the study given methodological and design issues?
- What research follows from the study to move the field forward?